



SOCIAL STRUCTURE

SOCIAL STATUS

INTRODUCTION

Certain people are ranked high in a society because they belong to royal family, respectable caste or occupation. All the people and groups of people are not equally respected in a society. This position or rank is called status in terms of Sociology. Every individual holds a certain position in his group and society with which he is affiliated. This position depends upon the duties he performs. These duties which create a position for him is called role. A status can be defined that it is a polar position socially attributed to a member of a group. And social role is the dynamic aspect of the corresponding status. Status is simply a collection of rights and duties and is used as singular. It is a cultural value attainable through the prescribed ways of behavior called social roles.

Definition

According to Duncan Mitchell: *Social status refers to "the position occupied by a person, family, or kinship group in a social system relative to others. This determines rights, duties and other behaviors, including the nature and extent of the relationship with persons of other statuses."*

Moris Ginsberg: *"A status is a position in a social group or grouping, a relation to other positions held by other individuals in the group or grouping".*

Horton & Hunt: status is defined as *"the rank or position of a person in a group, or of a group in relation to other groups."*



"Picture showing people from different statuses."

TYPES OF STATUS

There are two types of status

- (i) Ascribed status (ii) Achieved status

(i) Ascribed status

Definition:

According to Macdonis: "a Social position a person receives at birth or takes on involuntarily later in life."

"Ascribed status is the position which is assigned to individuals by culture, without reference to their innate abilities". Such status is attached with the physical existence of the individual.

Examples:

For instance, caste, age and sex are the ascribed statuses of the individual. They do not change and permanent in nature. They begin with the life and end with its end. Suppose a person, Mohammad Afzal is father of Sattar and Jabbar, brother of Ghulam Haider, father-in-law of Hamid, grandfather of Gogi, by caste he is a pathan.

and 84 years old. These are a few of the ascribed statuses of Mohammad Afzal

Characteristics of Ascribed Status:

1. It is attained at the time of birth.
2. It continues till death.
3. It is unchanged and permanent.
4. It doesn't require any effort or skill to achieve.
5. It is more important in rural and traditional societies.
6. Its area of influence is limited.

Determinants of Ascribed Status

1. **Ancestry:** The honor of a person's ancestry rests on legitimacy or illegitimacy, respect of the family and caste system. These are the factors of ascribed status. A child born in a royal family is called a prince.
2. **Gender:** Biologically the sexes have different status in our society. The male is given higher position in order of status as compare to female. This disparity of status is wider in rural areas of Pakistan.
3. **Caste:** Caste is an important element of status in Indo-Pakistan cultures. Especially, in rural areas, caste is even more important. The people attach caste with their names for distinction in community. Some castes are given higher status as Taga, Rajput, Pathan, Baloch, Syed, Jutt and Mughal. Some are considered the lowest in rank as washer man, cobbler, carpenter etc.
4. **Age:** Age is one of the important determinants of ascribe status. It has been observed that aged people are given more respect and honor in our society. On the other hand, youth are treated more lovingly and causally in our society. These two different kinds of expressions and treatment of society towards two different age groups is because of their age group.

(ii) Achieved status

Definition:

According to Cohen & Orbuch: *Status acquired through hard work and*

demonstrated ability is called achieved status.

"Achieved, the second of the types, is that status which requires specific qualities from the individuals in role performance".

Explanation:

These are not assigned to individuals by birth but are left open for competition and individual efforts. Culture provides certain ways (norms) and means for the achievement of certain status. The people compete each other (role) to get the goal (status).

Examples:

To get membership of National Assembly (MNA) in Pakistan, one has to qualify certain preliminary conditions of nationality and candidature and win elections of the corresponding constituency. This is an example of achieved status. The university would not give degree until one qualify for all the conditions of the degree—study of courses fixed, and qualify the examinations proposed. Hence to attain the status of degree holder, one will have to pass through the processes of time, money and labor. Your efforts in this direction are your roles for the corresponding degree. Certain qualities and capabilities are required here to attain an achieved status.

Characteristics of Achieved Status:

1. It is attained through efforts and skills.
2. It is dynamic and changeable.
3. It is important in urban and modern societies.
4. Its area of influence is vast.

Determinants of Achieved Status

Society does not assign status to people randomly. There is criteria of social approval or disapproval, honor or dishonor to people in societies. Generally, these are contained in social values. Those items of social life to which the people think important and worthwhile, are the determinants of social status.

1. Economic Resources: This is one of the most important determinants of a person's social status. The economic possession of an individual can be measured

and counted in easy terms and guessed easily as what status he enjoys in society. More the economically resourceful is someone, greater the status he occupies in society.

2. Occupation: In our society, the type of occupation, by which one earns money, is an important question. For example, the sweepers, brokers, barbers, cobblers, washer man and other menial servants how so rich can hardly be equivalent to the status of poor Rajputs, small agriculturists, government employees and others. This is the matter of occupation they adopt which is mostly determined through inheritance. Executive, Education, Judiciary, Police, Engineering and Medical are the services awarded higher status in our society.

3. Education: Higher education is a mark of respect in society. The degrees and certificates held from college and university are a symbol of status for the holder. Education itself is an end-value sometimes and mean-value mostly for higher social prestige in community.

4. Power: Power is the ability to control or influence the behavior of others. Those who attain more power in the society are treated more respectfully and their status is considered high. For example, a police man is regarded more respectable comparing with a school teacher. It is just because of the difference between power.

Comparison of Achieved & Ascribed Statuses

Characteristics of statuses	Ascribed status	Achieved status
Attainment	At birth/inherited	Effort & Skill
Duration	Permanent/till death	Can be changed
Importance	Traditional & Rural societies	Urban & modern societies
Influence	Limited	Broad & unlimited

OTHER TERMINOLOGIES

Status set

Each of us holds many statuses at once. The term status set refers to *all the statuses a person holds at a given time*. A teenage girl may be a daughter to her parents, a sister to her brother, a student at her school, and a goalie on her soccer team.

Status sets change over the life course. A child grows up to become a parent, a student graduates to become a lawyer, and a single person marries to become a husband or wife, sometimes becoming single again as a result of death or divorce. Joining an organization or finding a job enlarges our status set; withdrawing from activities makes it smaller. Over a lifetime, people gain and lose dozens of statuses.

Master status

Some statuses matter more than others. A master status is a *status that has special importance for social identity, often shaping a person's entire life*. For most people, a job is a master status because it reveals a great deal about a person's social background, education, and income. In a few cases, name is a master status; being in the Bush or Kennedy family attracts attention and creates opportunities.

A master status can be negative as well as positive. Take, for example, serious illness. Sometimes people, even longtime friends, avoid cancer patients or people with AIDS because of their illnesses. As another example, the fact that all societies limit the opportunities of women makes gender a master status.

Sometimes a physical disability serves as a master status to the point where we dehumanize people by seeing them only in terms of their disability.